



A Girl In A River : The Price Of Forgiveness



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Brief Introduction

Based on a true
story of Saba
Maqsood (2014)

Highlights honor
killing and
forgiveness
culture in
Pakistan

What happens
when justice and
family loyalty
collides



**What happens when
seeking justice
means defying your
own Blood?**



Objectives

The reason
for selection

Main
message

Summery

Systemic
problems
and reforms

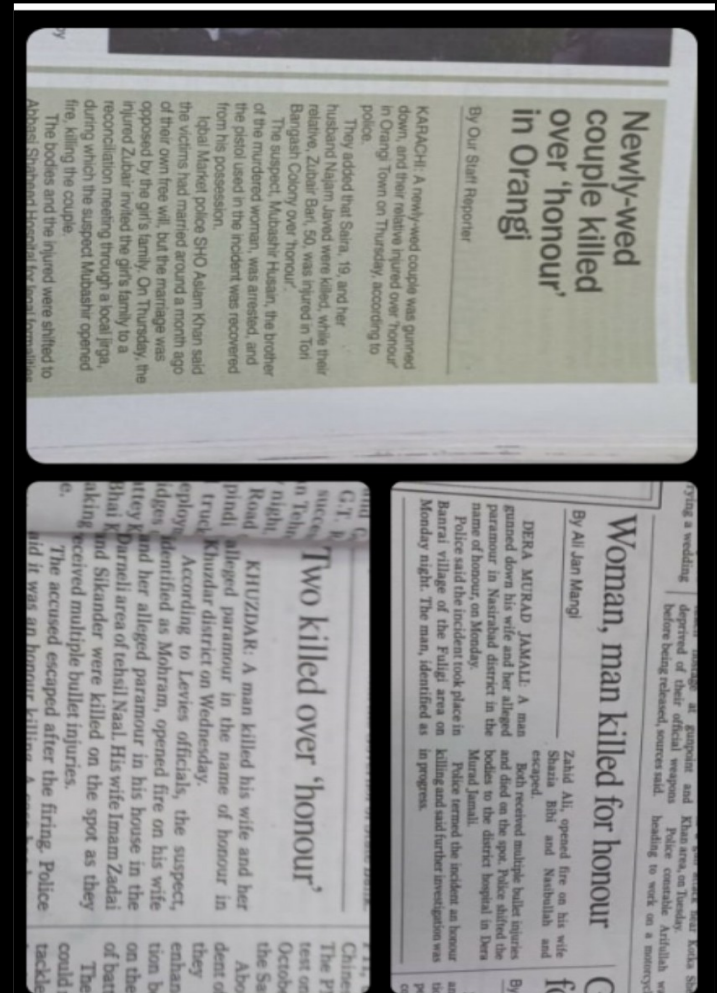
Conclusion
and
suggestions

Reason For Selection

- Powerful, emotional survivor led narrative
- Reflects thousands of untold stories
- Makes us question if survival is enough when justice is denied?

Honor Killings

- Honor killing is murder to restore family honor
- Bushra (2022): A teen from Faisalabad killed for having a phone
- 1005 women killed in Pakistan in 2022 in the name of honor according to the Human Rights Commission of Pakistan



Women's Rights

- Rights to education, safety, equality often denied
- Malala Yousafzai in 2012 Shot by Taliban for schooling activism
- 12 million girls were out of school in Pakistan UNICEF 2023
- Violence is used to control women's choices



Forgiveness Laws

- Qisas and Diyat laws allow family to forgive killers
- Samia Shahid 2016 British Pakistani killed by family
- When family is the perpetrator justice is impossible
- Law reformed only after 2016 due to pressure



Main Message

- Honor valued more than a woman's life
- Saba age 18 shot by father and uncle, survived
- Pressured to forgive
- Exposes how law favors perpetrators over victims

About the Director

- Sharmeen Obaid Chinoy
- First Pakistani woman to win 2 Oscars
- Saving Face 2012
- A Girl in the River 2016
- Named in Time 100 list in 2012



Her Filmmaking Style

- Focus women, injustice, extremism
- Features real survivors
- Uses journalism and cinema to create impact
- Aims to influence policy not just awareness



Reference to Documentaries

- **Saving Face 2012 :**
- Acid attack survivors led to Acid Control Act
- **Freedom Fighters 2018 :**
Women activists
- **Song of Lahore 2015:**
- A story of underrated singers attacked by extremists



Global Awareness

- Screened at United Nations
- Inspired international legal debates
- Became symbol for South Asian women's rights movement

NEW YORK, Mar 16 (APP): A screening of the Oscar-winning Pakistani filmmaker Sharmeen Obaid Chinoy's documentary 'A Girl in the River' was held at the UN to a packed-to-capacity hall. Organized by Pakistan's Mission to the UN and co-sponsored by UN-Women in conjunction with Equality Now, it was a side event during the 60th annual session of the Commission on Status of Women (CSW). The film and panel discussion which followed, attracted an audience from around over the world. Members of the Pakistan delegation, currently in New York to represent the country at CSW meetings, were also present. When Pakistan's Ambassador to the UN, Dr. Maleeha Lodhi introduced Raheela Durrani as the country's first female Speaker of the Balochistan Assembly, there was spontaneous applause from the audience.

Summary of the Documentary

- Saba marries by choice attacked by family
- Survives with bullet wounds
- Faces pressure to forgive in court
- Her story reflects thousands who do not survive

Legal Loophole

- Qisas lets family forgive is used to escape justice
- Saba's case shows how law becomes negotiation
- Justice becomes a private affair not a public right



Real World Echoes

- Qandeel Baloch 2016 Killed by her brother and parents tried to forgive
- Samia Shahid in 2016 Killed for marrying freely
- Fakhra Yunus in early 2000 Acid attack, died by suicide



Broader Statistics

Over 1000
honor
killings per
year
Human
Rights
Commissio
n of
Pakistan

88 percent
forgiven by
family
HRCP 2015

Only 6
percent
reach
conviction

Rural
women No
legal aid,
no media
voice

Strengths and Weaknesses

Strengths

- Real survivor's voice
- Legal critique with global impact
- Influenced national law in 2016

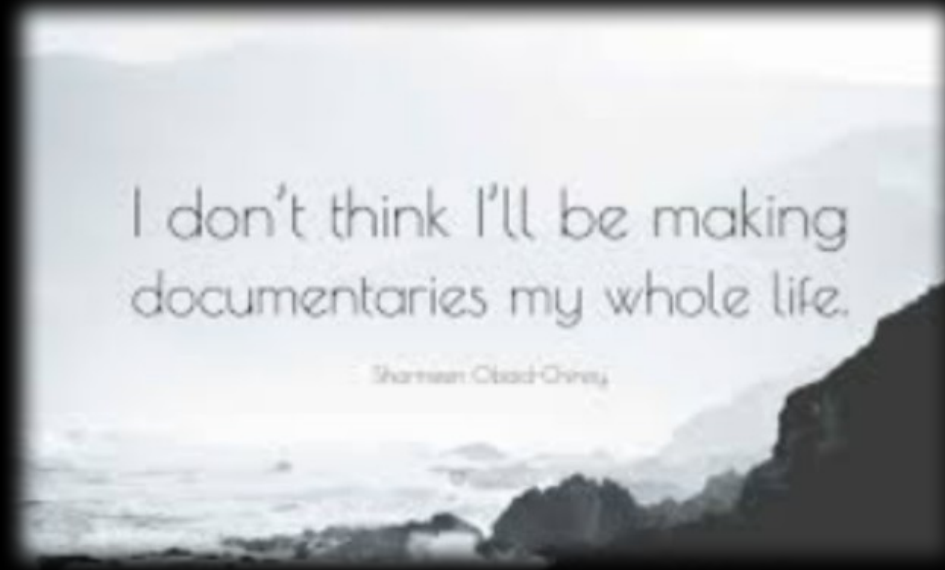
"It only takes one voice,
at the right pitch, to
start an avalanche."

DIANNA HARDY



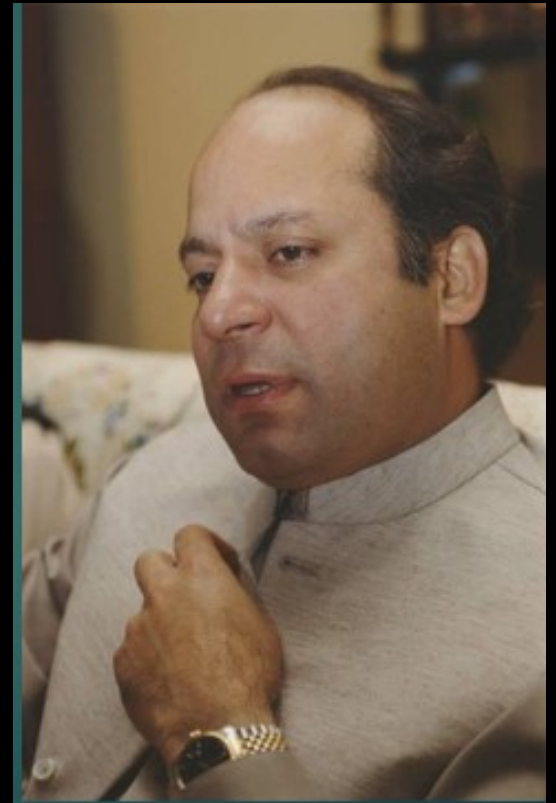
Weaknesses

- Focuses on one case only
- No long term follow up
- Minimal visuals, repetitive shots



Political Impact

- Oscar win February 28, 2016
- PM Nawaz Sharif promised law reform
- October 6, 2016, Parliament passed anti honor killing law
- Mandatory life sentence even with forgiveness



Final Reflection

Saba fought not just
attackers but

A flawed justice system

A silencing society

A family prioritizing shame
over love

Until we reform the system,
no woman is safe, not in the
courtroom, not in her home,
and not even in the river

Any Questions?